

1. More Conditional Probability

Q: A test for detecting cancer has the following accuracy

1. if a person has cancer, there is a 10% chance that the test will say that the person does not have it. This is called a “false negative.”
2. If a person does not have cancer, there is a 5% chance that the test will say that the person does have it. This is called a “false positive.”

For patients that have no family history of cancer, the incidence of cancer is 1%. Person X does not have any family history of cancer, but is detected to have cancer. What is the probability that the Person X does have cancer?

$S = \{(\text{Healthy}, \text{Positive}), (\text{Healthy}, \text{Negative}), (\text{Sick}, \text{Positive}), (\text{Sick}, \text{Negative})\}$

A is the event that Person X has cancer. B is the event that the test is positive.

$$P[A|B] = \frac{P[A \cap B]}{P[B]} = \frac{P[\{(S, P)\}]}{P[\{(S, P), (H, P)\}]} = \frac{0.0090}{0.0090 + 0.0495} \approx 15.4\%$$

Bayes Rule

For events E and F if $P[E] \neq 0$ and $P[F] \neq 0$, then $P[E|F] = \frac{P[E \cap F]P[F]}{P[E]}$

Proof: Using the formula for conditional probability,

$$\begin{aligned} \Pr[E|F] &= \frac{\Pr[E \cap F]}{\Pr[F]} \quad ; \quad \Pr[F|E] = \frac{\Pr[F \cap E]}{\Pr[E]} \\ \implies \Pr[E \cap F] &= \Pr[E|F] \Pr[F] \quad ; \quad \Pr[F \cap E] = \Pr[F|E] \Pr[E] \\ \implies \Pr[E|F] \Pr[F] &= \Pr[F|E] \Pr[E] \\ \implies \Pr[F|E] &= \frac{\Pr[E|F] \Pr[F]}{\Pr[E]} \end{aligned}$$

2. The Law of Total Probability and Bayes rule

For events E and F , $P[E] = P[E|F]P[F] + P[E|F^c]P[F^c]$

Proof:

$$\begin{aligned} E &= (E \cap F) \cup (E \cap F^c) \\ \implies P[E] &= P[(E \cap F) \cup (E \cap F^c)] = P[E \cap F] + P[E \cap F^c] \\ P[E] &= P[E|F]P[F] + P[E|F^c]P[F^c] \end{aligned}$$

1. Apply the union rule for mutually exclusive events.
2. By the definition of conditional probability.

If we **combine** Bayes rule and the Law of Total Probability, we get

$$P[F|E] = \frac{P[F \cap E]}{P[E]} = \frac{P[E|F]P[F]}{P[E]} \quad (\text{By definition of conditional probability})$$

$$P[F|E] = \frac{P[E|F]P[F]}{P[E|F]P[F] + P[E|F^c]P[F^c]} \quad (\text{By the law of total probability})$$

Q: Prove that for events E and F , $P[E^c|F] = 1 - P[E|F]$.

Proof: Since $E \cup E^c = S$, for any event F s.t. $P[F] \neq 0$,

$$\begin{aligned}
(E \cup E^c) \cap F &= S \cap F = F \\
(E \cup E^c) \cap F &= (E \cap F) \cup (E^c \cap F) \\
\implies P[(E \cap F) \cup (E^c \cap F)] &= P[F]
\end{aligned}$$

Since $E \cap F$ and $E^c \cap F$ are mutually exclusive,

$$\begin{aligned}
P[E \cap F] + P[E^c \cap F] &= P[F] \implies \frac{P[E^c \cap F]}{P[F]} = 1 - \frac{P[E \cap F]}{P[F]} \\
\implies P[E^c | F] &= 1 - P[E | F]
\end{aligned}$$

Q: